trended on Twitter in a four-month period at this time, found that the Congress was winning the sentiment game on Twitter until the BJP turned the tide from February 2019 after the Pulwama attack.[36]

What does all this mean? For one, it shows that Hindu nationalists do not have an indelible hold on social media, i.e., their dominance is not an automatic result of the nature of their messaging. Social media dominance is an outcome of the effort and attention that politicians put into it and how they engage with their audiences. The Congress, between 2017 and 2019, showed that it could fight the BJP on Twitter. The problem, however, is that Twitter remains the smallest of all the major social media platforms in India. It had only reached one-fifth of Indians by 2019. Facebook is far bigger. So, even though Rahul Gandhi was giving Modi a fight on Twitter, it tended to be a platform for debate among opinion-makers, not of mass outreach to voters. It was as if the larger shrinkage of the Congress was being replicated on social media.

The Congress seems to have missed a trick because Facebook and Instagram, which is dominated by younger people, are much bigger platforms in India, reaching about a third of voters. We saw the same higher engagement per post replicated for Rahul Gandhi on these platforms as well. However, unlike Twitter, he was so far behind Modi in overall size on these platforms that his gains proved to be irrelevant.

On Twitter, for every Rahul Gandhi follower, Modi had about five followers. In the case of Facebook, this ratio was as high as 1:14, on Instagram 1:34.[37] On Facebook, Narendra Modi's 44.02 million followers and 135.76 million interactions between May 2017 and May 2019 totally dwarfed Rahul Gandhi's 2.83 million page likes and 33.28 million interactions. Yet, in average rate of interactions per post, Gandhi was ahead of Modi (see Appendices 5–10). On Instagram, Modi (22.52 million followers and 222.44 million interactions) was over twenty times bigger than Gandhi (8,55,900 followers and 8.68 million interactions). This huge gap between the two leaders meant that any traction Gandhi got was ultimately rendered irrelevant. The BJP was so far ahead on Facebook and Instagram that the Congress was not even on the same playing field.